LoopCasts

Making a course

LoopCasts BV · Ghent
Internal document. Please do not share outside the team.
Handbook chapter 04

LOOPCASTS HANDBOOK · CHAPTER 04

Making a course

Internal handbook, chapter 4. Written by Pieter, with a bit by Marieke about ideas.

From idea to course (Marieke)

Ideas come from everywhere: customer mails, questions under our LinkedIn posts, things I run into myself, new releases of n8n. When somebody has an idea, they write it on **the whiteboard in the kitchen**. On Monday we look at the board and pick.

Before the cleaning company comes (every second Thursday) somebody takes a photo of the whiteboard, just in case. The photos are in the WhatsApp group.

Customers often ask "is there a course about X coming?". Honestly, we mostly do not know whether somebody asked for X before. Lotte sometimes remembers.

Once an idea is picked, I write a script in Word: what I will show, in which order, the example files. The scripts are in Dropbox in `Courses/scripts/`, more or less. Some are still on my old laptop. A script for a 10-minute video takes me about an hour and a half. I would not want to give that away, that is the real work and I enjoy it. Same for the recording itself.

Recording and editing (Pieter)

Marieke records with OBS. She puts the raw files in Dropbox, in `Courses/RAW/`, and tells me in WhatsApp. Sometimes she forgets to tell me and I find them on Monday.

I edit in DaVinci Resolve: cut the mistakes, add the intro and outro, zoom in where the text is small, normalise the audio. Editing is craft, about two hours per video. Then the boring part starts.

After the edit: the checklist

For **every video** (two a week, so about 100 a year):

1. Export from DaVinci (20 minutes, I can do something else meanwhile, but I have to remember to come back).
2. Upload to Vimeo through the website. Wait.
3. In Vimeo: type the title, type the description, pick the folder, set privacy to "only embed on loopcasts.example". If I forget the privacy setting the video is public. This happened twice.
4. Watch the video again to write down the **chapters** with timestamps (00:00 Intro, 01:24 The webhook node, ...). Customers love chapters. For a 12-minute video this takes 15 to 20 minutes.
5. Write the **description** for the course page: 3 or 4 sentences about what you learn. I am an editor, not a writer, so this takes me longer than it should.
6. Ask Yasmine for a **thumbnail** (she makes it in Canva from a template, changes the title and the number).

7. Copy the Vimeo embed code and mail it to Tom together with title, description and chapters, so he can make the page (chapter 2).
8. Update the **course catalogue** (see below).
9. Tell Yasmine the video is ready so she can announce it (chapter 5). I usually just shout across the office.

Steps 2 to 9 are about an hour per video when nothing goes wrong.

Subtitles

We do not have subtitles. We know we should: customers ask for them, about a third of our customers are not native English speakers, and it would be good for accessibility. We once got a quote from a subtitling company: € 1.50 per minute. With our back catalogue of roughly 9,000 minutes we decided to "look at it later".

Transcripts and search

Customers ask "in which video did Marieke explain the thing with the retry setting?". We do not know either. There is no search in the members area, and we have no text version of what is said in the videos. I usually answer from memory.

The course catalogue

`course catalogue.xlsx` is the list of all courses: title, level, number of videos, total duration, status (draft, live, retired), publication date, price if sold separately.

I keep it up to date. It is supposed to be the truth. Tom copies from it to the website, Yasmine uses it for the newsletter, Marieke uses it for quotes, Lotte uses it to answer customers.

In practice:

- The total duration I add up by hand from the video lengths. I write it however it comes out: `1h20`, `80 min`, `1:20:00`.
- Sometimes a course is live on the site while my sheet still says draft, because Tom was faster than me. Or the other way around.
- Levels: we agreed on beginner / intermediate / advanced, but older rows have other words.

An export is in `samples/course-catalogue.csv`.

When a tool changes

Our courses are about software that changes all the time. When n8n renames a node or changes a screen, the old video is wrong. We find out when a customer mails us. There is no list of "which video shows which version of which tool". I would like one, I have no idea how to make it without watching 9,000 minutes again.